WOMAN NEXT DOOR · BREAST CANCER AWARENESS

Know Your Normal

A mini guide to breast health for the women of Jamaica and beyond.

01 The facts, and why early matters

02 How to check your breasts

03 Lump or normal tissue?

04 Signs to see a doctor about

05 Screening and where to go in Jamaica

For her. With her. Beside her.

First edition · October 2026

01 · THE FACTS

Why this matters, ladies

October is Breast Cancer Awareness Month. This guide is our way of looking out for each other: knowing the facts, knowing our bodies, and knowing where to go.

2.3M	1 in 21	1,327
women worldwide were diagnosed with breast cancer in 2022	Jamaican women is expected to be diagnosed in her lifetime	new cases in Jamaican women in 2022, the leading cause of cancer death for women here

Sources: WHO's cancer agency (IARC); Jamaica Ministry of Health; Global Cancer Observatory estimates reported by the Jamaica Cancer Society.

Breathe: most lumps are not cancer. About 80% of breast lumps that are biopsied turn out to be benign (not cancer). Common harmless causes include cysts (small fluid-filled sacs), fibroadenomas (smooth, movable lumps, most common in women 18 to 35) and lumpy changes tied to your period. But only a doctor, with imaging and sometimes a biopsy, can tell for sure. So don't panic, and don't ignore it either. Get it checked.

What raises the risk

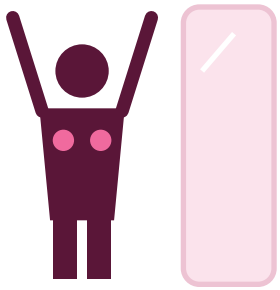
The biggest risk factors are simply being a woman and getting older. Others include obesity, alcohol, tobacco, a family history of breast cancer, certain inherited genes (like BRCA1 and BRCA2), and hormone therapy after menopause. Men can get breast cancer too, though it's rare (about 0.5 to 1% of cases). Importantly, **most women diagnosed have no family history**, so no history doesn't mean no risk.

What you can do

- Limit alcohol and avoid tobacco.
- Aim for a healthy weight and stay active in a way you enjoy (a pickleball session counts!).
- Ask your relatives about family history and tell your doctor.
- Learn your normal with a monthly self-check, and book screening when it's time (page 5).

Your monthly self-check

Do it a few days after your period ends, when breasts are least tender. If you no longer have periods, pick the same day each month, like the 1st. It takes about 10 minutes.



1. In the mirror

Arms down, then arms raised. Look for changes in shape, skin and nipples.



2. In the shower

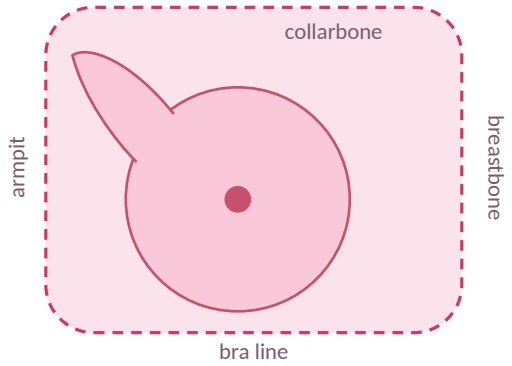
Soapy skin helps your fingers glide. One arm up, check with the other hand.



3. Lying down

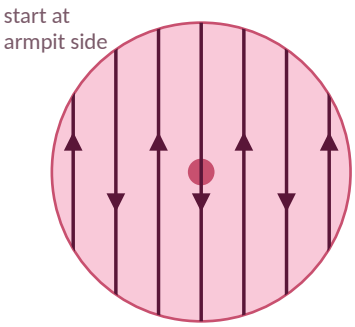
Pillow under your shoulder, arm behind your head. Tissue spreads evenly.

Where to check



Cover the whole dotted area, including the armpit.

How to move your fingers



Up and down in strips, small circles the size of a coin.

The technique

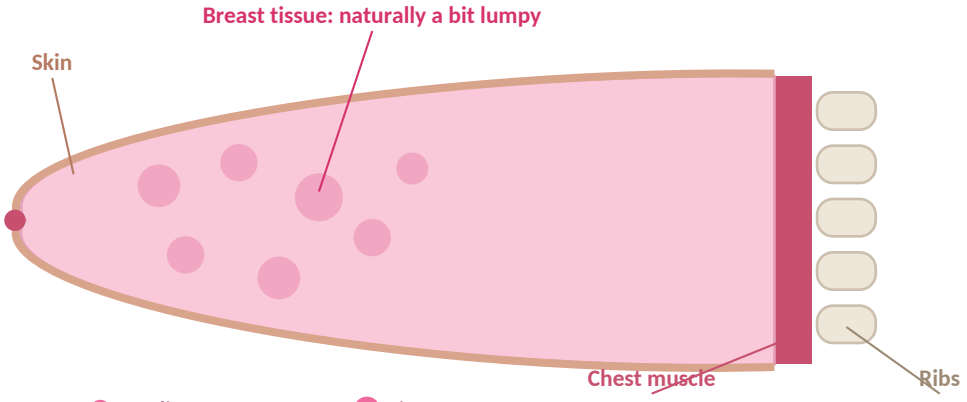
- Use the **pads of your three middle fingers**, not your fingertips.
- Make small, coin-sized circles at **three pressures**: light, medium, then firm (see the side view on the next page).
- Move in **up-and-down strips** from the armpit across to the breastbone, and from the collarbone down to the bra line.
- Gently squeeze each nipple and look for any discharge. Then repeat everything on the other side.

Know your normal, not a diagnosis. The American Cancer Society notes that self-exams alone haven't been shown to lower deaths from breast cancer. Their real value is helping you notice *changes* early. Self-checks support mammograms; they never replace them.

What you're actually feeling

Healthy breasts are not smooth inside. Knowing what's under your fingers helps you tell your usual lumpiness from something new.

What your fingers are feeling: a side view of the breast



● **Light** near the skin ● **Medium** the middle ● **Firm** near muscle and ribs

Usually normal	Get it checked
A lumpy or uneven texture spread through both breasts that feels about the same on each side.	A **new** lump, or one that feels different from the rest of your breast and from the other side.
Tenderness or extra lumpiness before your period that eases after it.	A lump or thickening that is **still there after your period**.
A firm, curved **ridge along the bottom** of each breast (where the bra wire sits).	A hard knot or lump in or near the **armpit**.
Hard, even bumps when you press firmly: those are your **ribs**, under the **chest muscle**.	Any area that has changed since last month, even if it doesn't hurt.

Muscle, ribs or a lump? Your chest muscle and ribs sit behind the breast tissue, so with firm pressure you'll reach them. They feel firm and even, and the same on both sides. What deserves attention is a spot in the breast tissue that feels **different** from the area around it and from the same spot on your other breast. Compare left and right every time.

You can't judge a lump by feel alone. Cancer lumps can be hard or soft, painful or painless, fixed or movable. Only imaging and sometimes a biopsy can tell for sure, so if something is new for you, let a doctor decide.

04 · SIGNS TO WATCH FOR

See a doctor if you notice

- A new lump in the breast or armpit
- Thickening or swelling of part of the breast
- Dimpling, puckering or irritated skin
- Redness or flaky skin on the nipple or breast
- A nipple that pulls inward, or nipple pain
- Nipple discharge (not breast milk), especially bloody
- Any change in breast size or shape
- Pain in one area that doesn't go away

Signs listed by the U.S. CDC and WHO. These can have other causes, and some cancers cause no symptoms at all.

05 · SCREENING AND WHERE TO GO

Book your mammogram

A mammogram can find cancer before you can feel it. **Jamaica's Ministry of Health advises average-risk women to start at 40.** Other bodies differ slightly (the American Cancer Society makes 40 to 44 optional, then yearly from 45). If breast cancer runs in your family, ask your doctor about starting earlier. With an **NHF card**, women aged 40 to 74 get **$3,000 a year** toward a mammogram; all you need to apply is your TRN.

Where	What they offer
Jamaica Cancer Society 16 Lady Musgrave Rd, Kingston 5 876-927-4265	Pap smears, education and support. *Its mammogram machine has been out of service since Aug 29, 2026, so call to check before you go.*
UHWI Women's Imaging Centre University Hospital of the West Indies, Mona	3D mammography. Call ahead to confirm screening appointments and costs.
Breast Health & Oncology Care Centre Andrews Memorial Hospital, 27 Hope Rd 876-920-7717	Specialist breast care: surgery, chemotherapy and radiation oncology consults.
Jamaica Reach to Recovery	Survivor-led support group: emotional support, help with pre-treatment test costs, prostheses and bras after surgery.
National Health Fund (NHF)	Mammogram subsidy (ages 40 to 74), breast cancer receptor test subsidy at the UHWI lab, and medication support.
Ministry of Health	Health information line: 888-ONE-LOVE (663-5683).

Details checked October 2026. Services and prices change, so please call before you go. Private imaging centres across the island also offer mammograms. Watch for free mammogram drives each October.

SOURCES

Where our information comes from

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- World Health Organization, Breast cancer fact sheet (2026). who.int/news-room/fact-sheets/detail/breast-cancer
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- Stony Brook Medicine, Understanding the different types of breast lumps. health.stonybrookmedicine.edu
- MD Anderson Cancer Center, What do cancerous breast lumps feel like? mdanderson.org
- CancerCare Manitoba, What is normal for my breasts? cancercare.mb.ca
- Michigan State University Women's Health; Millersville University Health Services; RWJBarnabas Health: self-exam steps and timing.
- UHWI, 3D mammography unit; Breast Health & Oncology Care Centre (breasthealthja.com); Jamaica Cancer Society listing (findyello.com).

All diagrams are original illustrations by Woman Next Door and are simplified for teaching.

A note from Woman Next Door

Everything in this guide comes from research Woman Next Door has gathered from the sources above. We work hard to keep it accurate, but information changes and mistakes can happen. If you spot anything incorrect or outdated, please let us know through the app so we can update it. Always do your own research before making important decisions.

This guide is general information, not medical advice. It can't diagnose anything or replace a visit to your doctor. If you notice a change in your breasts, please see a healthcare provider.